

Here is a screenshot of the interaction that took place on OSFY's Facebook wall



to leverage their contributions to FOSS to get better jobs or build themselves a better career."

Lack of awareness about the benefits of open source and the rapid adoption of proprietary software are the major hindrances in the development of a full-fledged open source ecosystem. Madhav Kobal, director and chief technology officer at OS3 Infotech Pvt Ltd, yet another open source solutions provider based in Mumbai, says, "When it comes to development, most Indian consumers are generally not aware of the options available in open source. And the Indian industry has a tendency to rely on existing proprietary models for business rather than explore other open options. Naturally, the demand for FOSS is relatively

low in India. But the good thing is Indian enterprises are realising the power of FOSS, and are now gradually using it for their mission-critical applications."

A common misconception is that if one is to create an ecosystem that supports FOSS, all that one does also has to be open source. But while that would be the ideal scenario, there is no compulsion to do so, feels Arun Kumar, general manager, Red Hat India. "We have seen many examples in the ecosystem where participants also thrive with the non-FOSS solutions. FOSS gives a leg-up to participants in the ecosystem to create and exploit great ideas that will be hard to implement in a non-FOSS system. I feel some of the biggest obstacles to the growth of Linux and FOSS in the country are the high piracy levels of proprietary software, the perceived lack of maturity of open source platforms, the non-availability of trained personnel with the right skill sets, and the lack of promotion for open source technology. However, there are practices and policies that are changing towards more open source adoption across both the public and private sectors."

It wouldn't be right to assume that there is a shortage of FOSS talent in the country. The growing demand for open source technologies has prompted Red Hat, the leading provider of open source software solutions, to expand globally and in APAC. The fact that Red Hat has its second largest R&D facility outside North America in India is a testament to the strength of the talent available here. "India boasts of the largest pool of Red Hat Certified Engineers (RHCE) and these skills are impacting FOSS deployment globally. It is not just professional talent in FOSS right now, but a growing community of future open source talent in the making as well," adds Kumar.

Industry experts believe that the FOSS ecosystem will take time to mature and this will happen once the user base in India grows to an optimum level. It's also important to overcome issues like the lack of advocacy and awareness, non-availability of trained skill sets and more.

So how does one remove these obstacles and attract the raw IT talent to take the plunge into the FOSS world?

One can innovate, tinker with, and create new things with open source, and the raw IT talent must be made aware of all these benefits, feels K Subramani, vice president, Security and Risk Management at IBM. "The whole idea is to make FOSS lucrative for the young IT talent. More start-ups based on open source should be encouraged in India and they should be given a discount on taxes. The Indian government should establish a centre of technology for smart young minds so that they can exercise their creative skills on FOSS and come up with their innovations. This will definitely help in promoting FOSS and tapping new talent," explains Subramani.

Chandresh Adhiya, chief executive officer of Qlogy, another open source solutions provider, says, "IT institutes and training providers should design a curriculum that is at par with the industry standards to attract the new talent pool and help them get jobs in the FOSS domain.